



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

IT USED TO BE SAID THAT WHAT BENGAL THINKS TODAY, INDIA THINKS TOMORROW, OR WHEN BENGAL SNEEZES, INDIA CATCHES A COLD. THE BENGALI MUSLIM HAS SNEEZED.

Muslims into a new public dimension.

No fact of politics is an absolute fact. The finest Indian Muslim leader of the 20th century, Maulana Abul Kalam Azad—he was a genuine maulana, a passionate Indian, and a charismatic leader—chose to remain with the “Hindu” Congress, because he would not condemn a party refashioned by the spirit of Gandhi just because a few elements within it had strayed from the vision of the father of the nation. He believed that the best interests of Muslims lay in cooperation with Hindus, despite the ugly and vicious demonisation of Hindus and the Congress by the Muslim League. The contemporary variation of this belief is at the essence of Nitish Kumar’s politics. He believes that he can bring value to the lives of Bihari Muslims despite an alliance with the BJP. Periodically he sets up MPs to fulminate against BJP hardliners, but he does not break his alliance.

The important fact, of course, is not Nitish Kumar’s attitude to Muslims, but the Muslim attitude to Nitish Kumar. The elections of 2009 were a decisive test. A large section of the

Muslim vote did go to Nitish Kumar, displaying a growing maturity of nuance in judgement. The real paradox, which many BJP leaders will be loath to admit, is the change that participation in power has brought to the BJP in Bihar. It has, as part of the Government, been partner in policies that have offered reservations for the poorer sections, or castes, among Muslims.

The Bihar model has affected thinking in Delhi as well. BJP President Rajnath Singh asserted, during the release of the Urdu edition of L.K. Advani’s autobiography in Delhi, that the BJP was not opposed to reservations for impoverished Muslims. He would not extend that generosity to those Muslims who were well-off. Nothing wrong with that. Reservations for the “creamy layer” of Backward Castes and Dalits should be re-examined, although no one has the courage to articulate this. In principle positive discrimination is the right of the poor, who are often denied its benefits by their privileged kinfolk. Compulsions of power can turn theory on its head. Democracy is particularly adept at this kind of healthy somersault.

 Community representation touched a low with just 30 Muslim MPs out of 543 in the 15th Lok Sabha, accounting for 5 per cent of its strength.

54.6
per cent of Muslims in villages have never attended school in comparison to the national average of 40.8 per cent.